and anticipation—that the perspective of time opens up for us, like our small, lit clearing.[121] Time opens up our limited access to the world.[122] Time, then, is the form in which we beings, whose brains are made up essentially of memory and foresight, interact with the world: it is the source of our identity.[123]

And of our suffering as well.

Buddha summed this up in a few maxims that millions of human beings have adopted as the foundations of their lives: birth is suffering, decline is suffering, illness is suffering, death is suffering, union with that which we hate is suffering, separation from that which we love is suffering, failure to obtain what we desire is suffering.[124] It's suffering because we must lose what we have and are attached to. Because everything that begins must end. What causes us to suffer is not in the past or the future: it is here, now, in our memory, in our expectations. We long for timelessness, we endure the passing of time: we suffer time. Time is suffering.

Such is time, and because of this we are fascinated and troubled by it in equal measure—and perhaps because of this, too, dear reader, my brother, my sister, you are holding this book in your hands. Because it is nothing but a fleeting structure of the world, an ephemeral fluctuation in the happening of the world, that which is capable of giving rise to what we are: beings made of time. That to which we owe our being, giving us the precious gift of our very existence, allowing us to create the fleeting illusion of permanence that is the origin of all our suffering.

The music of Strauss and the words of Hofmannsthal sing of this with devastating delicacy:[125]

I remember a little girl . . .
But how can that be . . .
Once I was that little Resi,
and then one day I became an old woman?
. . . If God wills it so, why allow me to see it?
Why doesn't he hide it from me?
Everything is a mystery, such a deep mystery . . .
I feel the fragility of things in time.
From the bottom of my heart, I feel we should cling to nothing.

Everything slips through our fingers.
All that we seek to hold on to dissolves.
Everything vanishes, like mist and dreams . . .
Time is a strange thing.
When we don't need it, it is nothing.
Then, suddenly, there is nothing else.
It is everywhere around us. Also within us.
It seeps into our faces.